

grams was cracked by Donald Harden. It contained a misspelled message in which the killer claimed that he was collecting slaves for the afterlife.

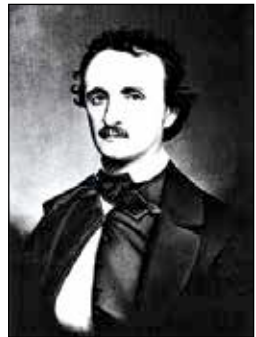
The Zodiac Killer's 'Three part cipher' consisted of three different parts being mailed to three different newspapers in mid 1969. The cover letters were similar and included confessions to earlier killings and threats to kill even more people if his ciphers were not published on the front page of respective newspapers. Further, they also stated that the ciphers contained his identity.

Another one of Zodiac's ciphers was sent to the San Francisco chronicle. It was a 148-character cipher, written at the top of a letter. The cipher was followed by Zodiac killer's crosshair symbol.

Edgar Allan Poe

Edgar Allan Poe was an American author and cryptography enthusiast. Considered the inventor of detective fiction genre, he pursued activities in the field of cryptography as well. He invited submissions of ciphers and puzzles through advertisements in newspapers and then proceeded to solve them. He went on to publish an essay on cryptography called "A Few Words on Secret Writing". His novels incorporated ciphers and encryption as a part of the story (Yes, just like Dan Brown). His eventual success in the field of cryptography can be attributed less to his knowledge of the subject and more to his knowledge of the magazine and the newspaper culture. Largely ignorant about the field of cryptography, the general public was awestruck by Poe's method of solving a simple substitution cryptogram. Poe created a sensation through his articles and ended up popularizing ciphers in print media, a trend which continues to this day. Many future notable figures in cryptography were heavily inspired and influenced by Poe's work.

Poe released two ciphers as a challenge for his readers. They remained unsolved for a long time, till the first of these was cracked in 1992. A contest was established for the solution of the second cipher which was eventually cracked in 2000. There has been a revival of interest in his work due to the recent movie "The Raven".



Edgar Allan Poe loved cryptography